building of worship structures on sites that hurt the faith of others," he said.

The comments came on the same day that the Supreme Court intervened in the Sambhal case, staying a notice issued by municipal authorities allowing Hindu worship and holy baths in a well located near the masjid. The court also sought a status report from the government on the matter. Two days earlier, on January 8, the Allahabad High Court had stayed trial court proceedings related to the mosque until February 25. It was a November 19 directive by the local civil court for a survey of the site that put wheels on the controversy; the HC stay was in response to the mosque managing committee's challenge of that order. An advocate commissioner's 45-page survey report, prepared in accordance with the now-impugned order, was submitted on January 3—in a sealed cover, as per instructions issued by the SC in November.

Advocate Hari Shankar Jain, who represents the Hindu activists pursuing the case, told INDIA TODAY, "The court may have paused proceedings, but the movement is unstoppable. This revolution is like a *sailaab* (flood) that cannot be contained." Jain's caseload is a reasonable index of the presaged deluge: it includes petitions against the Gyanvapi mosque in Varanasi, the Shahi Idgah mosque in Mathura, the Bhojshala-Kamal Maula complex in Dhar, and even the Taj Mahal in Agra and Qutub Minar in Delhi. In recent months, UP's lower courts have seen a surge in petitions by fringe Hindu groups seeking rights over Muslim lands and places of worship. This has led to contentious surveys and administrative actions, evoking criticism from the Opposition over the Yogi government's "overzealousness". Besides the aforementioned cases, there are petitions against the Shamsi Shahi mosque in Badaun and the Atala Masjid in Jaunpur.

Adding to the legal turmoil, fresh petitions were filed before the Supreme Court on January 5 seeking a vacation of its stay on lower courts entertaining specific pleas under the Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act, 1991, and issuing orders for surveys. The SC ordered the stay on December 12 as it heard challenges to the constitutional validity of the Act, which mandates a preservation of status quo on all religious sites as they were on August 15, 1947. With the next hearing slated for February 17, the pot has only been kept simmering. Political rhetoric is at a peak, meanwhile, with each side interpreting the court's decision through its ideological lens. For the BJP, it offers an opportunity to consolidate its Hindutva base while keeping the Opposition on the edge. However, party spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi denies their involvement in the mosque petitions. "The people are exercising their rights, and the courts are hearing these cases. There is no need to involve politics in these matters," he says.

Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav has largely refrained from direct comments, though he did take a dig at the "new trend" of ordering archaeological surveys at the drop of a hat. On December 29, he let go of this quip: "There is a Shivling under the CM's residence also. That too should

IN RECENT MONTHS, UTTAR PRADESH'S LOWER COURTS HAVE SEEN A SURGE IN PETITIONS BY FRINGE HINDU GROUPS

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SAMBHAL CASE TIMELINE

NOV. 19, 2024: Civil judge orders survey of Mughal-era Shahi Jama Masjid after a petition claims it was built on 16th-century temple site

NOV. 24: Violence erupts during second survey. Four people, all Muslim, die in the clashes

NOV. 29: SC asks Sambhal trial court to pause proceedings, seals survey report and allows mosque panel to challenge civil court order

DEC. 1: UP government forms a three-member judicial commission to investigate Sambhal violence

JAN. 2, 2025: Advocate commissioner submits sealed 45-page report of masjid survey to a local court in Chandausi, UP

JAN. 8: Allahabad HC stays trial court proceedings in Sambhal Masjid matter till Feb. 25

JAN. 10: SC stays 'notice' issued by Sambhal authorities regarding worship/ holy bath at well near Shahi Jama Masjid



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